19.7 The next era of digital trust

The challenges ACME faced are not unique. They are early signs of a wider shift that is already happening. As digital solutions are applied to more and more domains, the number and complexity of authorization decisions will continue to grow. The use of AI to develop applications is likely to accelerate this trend. More interactions will cross organizational boundaries. More actions will be performed by services and agents instead of people. More decisions will rely on real-time context, including signals about device posture, environment, and operational state. Authorization’s surface area will not stabilize. It will expand.

Organizations relying on static models and embedded decision logic will encounter the same issues ACME did: inconsistent behavior across systems, friction in collaboration, and growing difficulty in explaining or controlling how authority is exercised. These challenges will not emerge all at once but develop gradually as systems evolve and expectations rise. But they will appear. In this environment, *dynamic authorization is no longer a luxury. It's essential*.

The practices we've discussed in this book—externalizing policy, incorporating context, governing signals, and evaluating decisions at runtime—are not tied to any specific technology stack or moment in time. They represent fundamental shifts in how software systems operate. As these systems become more distributed, automated, and interconnected, the demand for consistent, explainable decision-making will only grow.

This is especially true as agents become more capable and autonomous. Systems that plan and act over time require adaptable authorization models that can change with conditions. Decisions must be evaluated continuously rather than assumed. Delegation must be explicit and bounded. Trust must be enforced through policy, not inferred from static configuration.

The ideas in this book are not a snapshot of current practice. They serve as a foundation for what comes next. What ACME experienced as a gradual realization will become more immediate for others. The gap between decision surface and decision infrastructure, illustrated in figure 19.1, will